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ACADEMIC VAULT

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Mental Health and Stress: Coping Skills That Actually Help

Understand stress, spot warning signs and know when to ask for help

HEALTH & WELLBEING

Health & Wellbeing

General Studies (GST / CED)
GST Directorate | 100L

Written for students, by students.

Practical notes, worked examples, practice questions and a revision plan.

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Independent study support | Not an official UNIZIK publication

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Why this pack exists

First year brings new academic pressure, financial strain and social change at once. This pack explains the stress response, distinguishes normal pressure from warning signs, teaches practical coping skills and sets out how and where to seek help.

This is a student-written study companion, not a reproduced lecture handout or a leaked examination paper. Use it to organise the topics you are taught, practise the kind of thinking your course rewards, and walk into class with better questions.

What you will be able to do

- Explain the stress response and differentiate acute from chronic stress.
- Recognise warning signs that need professional support.
- Apply evidence-based coping strategies for study and daily life.
- Know where to seek help on and off campus.

How to use this pack

1. Skim the whole pack once in 20 minutes so you know what is inside.
2. Work through one section at a time with your lecture note and recommended text beside you.
3. Attempt the practice questions before reading the answers. Mark what you missed.
4. Use the final checklist to plan your revision week, one tick per study session.

> **Free to download, always**
> This pack is free. There is no fee, no subscription and no payment step before download, and the full PDF is not watermarked or locked. Share the link with a coursemate instead of forwarding the file.

> **Confirm your official course outline**
> Course codes, credit units and outlines can differ by department and session. Treat this pack as supplementary support and confirm the current outline with your lecturer, course rep or departmental handbook before an assessment.

What stress is doing

Stress is a physiological response to demand. It is useful in short bursts and harmful when unrelieved.

- Acute stress sharpens attention briefly; chronic stress impairs memory, sleep and immunity.
- Common signs: persistent worry, irritability, poor concentration, changes in sleep and appetite.
- Burnout combines exhaustion, cynicism and reduced effectiveness.
- Some stress is normal; being unable to function is not a character flaw.
- Substance use may feel like relief but worsens anxiety and sleep.
- Naming what you feel reduces its intensity and helps you act.

Coping that works

Choose strategies that address the cause and regulate the body.

- Break overwhelming work into the next single action.
- Use slow breathing for two minutes to reduce acute arousal.
- Protect sleep, meals and movement even during exams.
- Schedule worry time rather than worrying all day.
- Talk to one trusted person weekly.
- Reduce comparison with social media; other people's highlights are edited.

> **When to seek help**
> Seek professional support if low mood lasts more than two weeks, if you cannot attend classes, or if you have thoughts of harming yourself. This is a medical issue, not weakness.

Getting support

Help exists, and using it early makes a difference.

- Campus counselling unit or guidance office.
- University health centre for assessment and referral.
- A trusted lecturer, level adviser or chaplain.
- National mental-health helplines and teaching-hospital services.
- A trusted friend or family member who can accompany you.
- In an emergency, go to the nearest hospital or call emergency services.

Stress is a response, not a weakness

Stress is the body's response to a demand it perceives as exceeding its resources. In short bursts it is useful: it sharpens attention before an examination. It becomes harmful when it is chronic, when the demand never lifts and the body never returns to baseline. That is when sleep, appetite, concentration and immunity begin to suffer.

University creates specific stressors: financial pressure, academic workload, distance from family, crowded accommodation, uncertain outcomes and social comparison. Naming the specific stressor matters, because "I am stressed" cannot be acted on while "I cannot sleep because I am worried about fees" can.

Mental health is not the absence of difficulty. It is the capacity to function, to feel, and to seek help when functioning is impaired. Everyone has bad weeks; the question is whether the bad weeks are becoming the pattern.

What helps, in order of evidence